

LOW ACID FOODS



Adults

Q

Why must low-acid foods such as meat, poultry, and vegetables be processed in a pressure canner rather than a boiling water canner?

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ANSWER

Because pressure canners reach 240°F, high enough to kill *Clostridium botulinum* spores.

FUN FACT

Pressure canners get 28°F hotter than boiling water canners to ensure safety.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

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What is the correct headspace to leave in jars when pressure canning low-acid vegetables?

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ANSWER

1 inch headspace

FUN FACT

Proper headspace ensures adequate heating and prevents jar boiling over.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

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How should you prepare your pressure canner before raising the pressure to process low-acid foods?

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ANSWER

Venting the canner for 10 minutes to remove trapped air

FUN FACT

Trapped air lowers canner temperature, risking unsafe processing.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

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How often should the dial gauge on a pressure canner be tested for accuracy?

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ANSWER

At least once a year or after it has been dropped

FUN FACT

An inaccurate gauge can result in unsafe canning temperatures.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

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If you live at 3,000 feet altitude and use a dial-gauge pressure canner for low-acid vegetables, what pressure should you use?

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ANSWER

12 pounds pressure

FUN FACT

Pressure must be increased at higher altitudes to reach target temperature.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

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What pressure should be used at sea level in a weighted-gauge pressure canner for low-acid vegetables?

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ANSWER

10 pounds pressure

FUN FACT

Weighted gauges rely on the weight's rock or jiggle to maintain pressure.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

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Why is it unsafe to can low-acid foods using a boiling water canner or steam canner?

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ANSWER

Because these methods do not reach temperatures high enough to kill botulism bacteria.

FUN FACT

Only pressure canning reaches 240°F needed to destroy Clostridium botulinum spores.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

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How long should you boil home-canned meat at altitudes below 1,000 feet as an extra safety measure?

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ANSWER

10 minutes

FUN FACT

Boiling destroys any botulism toxins that may exist despite proper canning.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

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What is the recommended jar filling method for canning meats in a pressure canner?

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ANSWER

Fill hot jars, leaving 1 inch headspace

FUN FACT

Hot packing improves food quality and reduces air trapped in jars.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game



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What should you do if you drop the lid of your pressure canner before using it?

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ANSWER

Have the dial gauge accuracy checked again before using

FUN FACT

Lid impact can cause gauge misalignment leading to unsafe canning.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

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Which of these is a sign that your pressure canner is properly vented before pressurizing?

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ANSWER

Steam flows steadily from the petcock for 10 minutes

FUN FACT

Steady steam release means all air has been expelled for safe processing.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

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When canning low-acid foods above 1,000 feet altitude using a weighted gauge pressure canner, what pressure should you use?

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ANSWER

15 pounds pressure

FUN FACT

Altitude affects pressure needed to maintain 240°F in the canner.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

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Why must you never can meat products or combination foods for which you do not have research-based processing times?

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ANSWER

Because unsafe processing times can allow botulism toxin to develop

FUN FACT

Only tested recipes ensure pathogen destruction in home canning.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

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What happens during the pressure canner's natural cool down time after processing low-acid foods?

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ANSWER

Organisms continue to be destroyed as the canner cools

FUN FACT

Cooling down gradually is part of the total processing time for safety.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

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Q

How does altitude affect pressure canning of low-acid foods?

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ANSWER

You must increase pressure to maintain 240°F processing temperature

FUN FACT

Lower atmospheric pressure at altitude means water boils at lower temps.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

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What is the main cause of unsafe low-acid canned foods if proper procedures are not followed?

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ANSWER

**Survival and growth of
Clostridium botulinum causing
botulism**

FUN FACT

*Botulism toxin nerves can cause
paralysis and death if ingested.*

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

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Which type of pressure canner gauge does NOT require annual accuracy testing?

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ANSWER

Weighted gauge canners

FUN FACT

Weighted gauges rely on a weight's movement, not mechanical components.

Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home

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When using a dial-gauge pressure canner, what pressure is recommended for processing low-acid foods at 0-2000 feet altitude?

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ANSWER

11 pounds pressure

FUN FACT

Dial gauge readings differ with altitude adjustments for safety.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

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What should you do if you notice the petcock or vent port of your pressure canner is blocked before processing?

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ANSWER

Clean or unblock it before starting to ensure correct pressure and venting

FUN FACT

Blocked vents trap dangerous air, preventing proper heating.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

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Why must jars be wiped clean of food residue before sealing in pressure canning low-acid foods?

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ANSWER

To ensure a good seal and prevent bacterial contamination

FUN FACT

Food residue can keep lids from sealing correctly, risking spoilage.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game